

System Discovery Questions

Use this worksheet during the discovery conversation to capture how Project Hope currently manages inventory, donations, distribution, reporting, users, equipment, budget, and future system goals. The answer boxes are fillable on an iPad, computer, or most PDF apps.

Meeting date

People interviewed

Location / area observed

Primary objective

Understand the real workflow before recommending technology. Preserve what works, identify pain points, and focus on a practical, low-cost, maintainable improvement plan.

Opening note

Lead with: 'Can you show me exactly how the process works today?' Then use the sections below to fill in details.

Current Process

1. Can you walk me through the current inventory process from the moment food arrives to the moment it leaves?

2. What spreadsheets are currently used, and what is each one responsible for?

3. Who updates the spreadsheets, and how often are they updated?

4. Are multiple people editing the same files, or does one person usually manage them?

5. Where are the spreadsheets stored today: one computer, shared drive, cloud storage, email, USB drive, or something else?

6. What parts of the current process work well and should be preserved?

7. What parts are frustrating, slow, confusing, or error-prone?

Inventory Tracking

8. What information do you track for each item? For example: item name, quantity, category, expiration date, donor, date received, location, or special restrictions.

9. Do you track individual items, cases, pounds, pallets, or some combination of those?

10. Do you need to track expiration dates or best-by dates?

11. Do you need alerts for food that is close to expiring?

12. Do you track where items are physically stored, such as shelves, freezers, refrigerators, pantry areas, or back stock?

13. Are there categories that matter most, such as canned goods, produce, meat, dairy, frozen food, hygiene items, baby supplies, or pet food?

Donations and Distribution

14. Do you need to track where donations came from?

15. Are there recurring donors whose donations should be reported separately?

16. Do you need receipts or reports for donors?

17. How is food distribution tracked when clients receive items?

18. Do you track inventory leaving the building by item, by weight, by household, or only as a general total?

19. Are there monthly, quarterly, or yearly reports you are required to provide?

Reporting and Compliance

20. What reports do you currently create from the spreadsheets?

21. Who receives those reports?

22. Are there any government, nonprofit, grant, or partner reporting requirements?

23. Are there audit or recordkeeping requirements that the system must support?

24. How long do records need to be kept?

25. Are there privacy concerns related to client information?

Users and Access

26. Who would need to use the system?

27. Are users mostly staff, volunteers, board members, or outside partners?

28. How comfortable are users with computers?

29. Would the system need different access levels, such as read-only, inventory editor, administrator, or reporting user?

30. Would people need to access it from more than one computer?

31. Would anyone need to access it from home or from a mobile device?

Equipment and Budget

32. What computers or tablets are currently available?

33. Is the internet connection reliable at the food bank?

34. Is there Wi-Fi in the areas where inventory is handled?

35. Is there any budget at all for software, hardware, hosting, barcode scanners, labels, or backups?

36. Would donated hardware be an option if needed?

37. Do you already use Microsoft 365, Google Workspace, Dropbox, QuickBooks, or another nonprofit software platform?

Future System Goals

38. What would make the biggest difference immediately?

39. What is the one thing you wish the current system did better?

40. What would success look like six months from now?

41. Would you prefer improving the current spreadsheet system first, or exploring a simple replacement system?

42. How much change can the organization realistically absorb at one time?

43. Who would be the best person to test a prototype or review early ideas?

44. Is there a quiet time of year when system changes would be less disruptive?

45. Are there any past attempts to improve the system that I should know about?

Additional Notes**Top pain points observed****Quick wins / low-risk improvements****Potential risks or constraints****Recommended next step**